

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 339

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1952-1953

Coverage Date: Ca. 1950s

Place Coverage: !Kung San, Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia

Section Title(S)

Marriage regulations: the incest taboo and its expression in avoidances

The !Kung extend the incest taboo to certain categories of persons outside the nuclear family because they hold that the relationships resemble the relationships of the nuclear family and that it would therefore be incestuous to unite them in marriage. A man will say explicitly that he must not marry this or that woman because it would be 'like' marrying his mother, daughter, or sister.

582
[Regulation Of Marriage](#)

835
[Kinship Regulation Of Sex](#)

The sexual constraints required between persons to whom the immediate or the extended incest taboo applies find expression in the marriage regulations and, in a secondary way, I believe, in certain avoidances which express constraint, namely: (1) Sexual joking and sexual insults, which are permitted between persons who have the joking relationship and must be avoided by others. (2) A sitting taboo. The same persons who must avoid sexual joking must also avoid sitting close to each other or to each other's family fires—with two exceptions, namely: (a) parents and offspring, who must never make sexual jokes but who do not at any age observe the sitting taboo; and (b) all young children, including siblings. The !Kung believe that the persons who must observe the sitting taboo should not allow their genital organs to touch the same spot. No great distance need separate these persons when they sit. About 18 inches is a minimum but is sufficient. The taboo is applied without sex differentiation: men must not sit near men or women, or women near women or men if they do not have the joking relationship. (3) With the exception of siblings of any age, the same persons who avoid joking avoid using each other's names in direct address. They use a kin term instead or the men may use a respect term for each other—*!nau*, 'old man'. (4) Brothers and sisters do not sit near each other when they reach adolescence and, after marriage, when they have dwelling-places of their own, do not enter each other's shelters (shelters). (5) Parents and SoWi and DaHu, in addition to

593
[Family Relationships](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

606
[Parents-In-Law And Children-In-Law](#)

835
[Kinship Regulation Of Sex](#)

observing the joking, sitting, and name avoidances, do not enter each other's schirms and do not speak to each other in the first few years of their affinal relationship. They are the only persons in !Kung society who must avoid speaking together. After three children have been born, this avoidance is eased somewhat. In-laws may then speak occasionally; once in two or three days would be considered permissible. This interesting avoidance, so varied in intensity and so widely spread in human societies, appears in !Kung society to afford whatever benefits it has without imposing great hardship at any time. A daughter-in-law may lean her schirm upon her husband's parents' schirm and build her fire only about four or five feet away, and what she wants to say to her parents-in-law she says aloud to her husband or child and her parents-in-law overhear and respond in like manner. A son-in-law also could communicate in this way. I think only a !Kung or an informed observer would know that the in-laws were not speaking directly to each other.

The symbolism or expression of sexual constraint which underlies the joking and sitting avoidances is also observable in the modesty of these people. I believe that their modesty is not obedience to a specific taboo, like the sitting taboo, but is a more general response to being constantly in the presence of persons to whom the incest taboo applies, before whom any expression of sex would be improper. The general demeanour of the !Kung is modest. The dancing, if it gives any expression at all to sexuality or eroticism, conveys it with such restraint and delicacy as to be in extreme contrast to the dancing of the neighbouring Bantu tribes. Both men and women among the !Kung are exceedingly modest about exposing their genital 340 organs and, though the women's breasts are naked (breasts are associated with nursing, not sex), the women would not expose their buttocks, which are definitely associated with sex, as the position for sexual intercourse is for the man to be at the back of the woman. When they urinate or defecate, men, women, and all but young children who are not yet toilet trained go away from the werf and squat behind bushes or in the tall grass out of sight.

514
Elimination

831
Sexuality

834
General Sex
Restrictions

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)